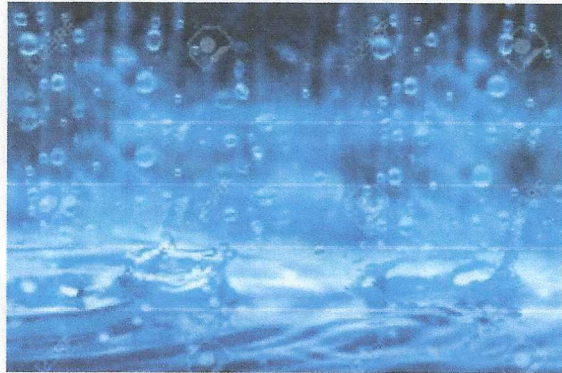


February

*February brings the rain,
Thaws the frozen lake again*

Sara Coleridge



Some did you know? facts about February

- ❖ Its name comes from Februum, Latin for purification
- ❖ It's the last month of winter
- ❖ Old English names – Solmonath (mud month) and Kalemonath (cabbage month)
- ❖ Finnish name Helmikuu, the pearl month – the snow melts into droplets which freeze again
- ❖ Most European names for February are icy
- ❖ And best of all this short month begins in winter and ends in spring!

The flowers of the month



Violet



Primrose



Iris

The birth stone



February's birth stone is the amethyst,
thought to attract love!

February

Maybe you already know the old appellation for the month as February Fill-dyke?

These two paintings are both named February Fill-dyke



A Victorian landscape by Benjamin Williams Leader



A 1976/7 scene in Wigan by Peter Brook

Special February Days



February 14th originated as a feast day honouring saints named Valentinus. Legend has it that St Valentine of Rome, imprisoned for performing weddings for soldiers, who at that time were forbidden to marry, restored sight to the blind daughter of his judge, and before his execution he wrote her a letter signed "Your Valentine" as a farewell.

Today it is celebrated around the world more as a commercial celebration of romantic love with the hearts and the winged cupids.



Around the world, Singaporeans, Chinese and South

Koreans spend the most money on Valentine's gifts

It's said to be the day when birds start mating, that birds propose to each other or marry on that day, and it is the day that plants and flowers start to grow!



Wish we had a few of these.

Maybe next year?

NB the pearly raindrops on the petals

Birds

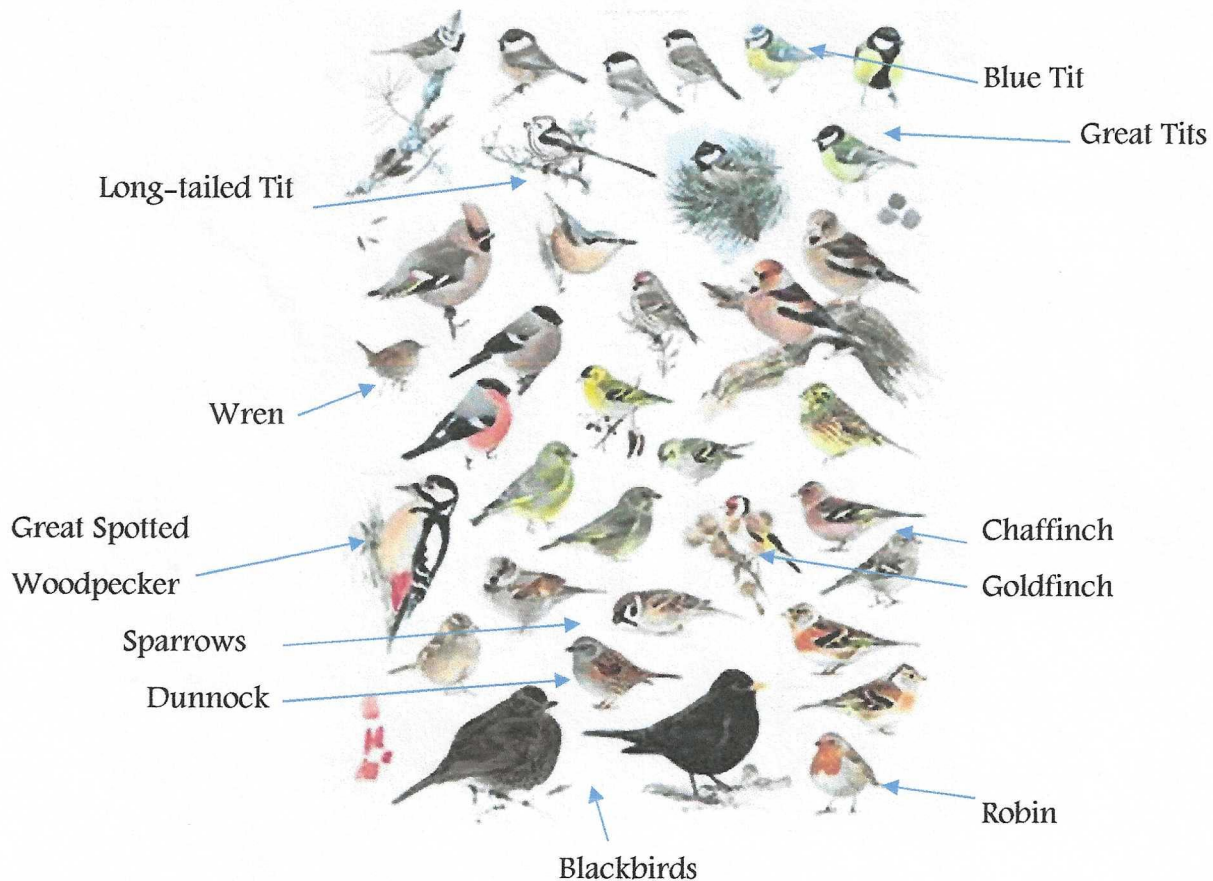
Which animal do we see most of?

When you go out of your door you might see dogs and their walkers or the odd cat in the street but always you'll see birds.

Which are most common in your street? Jackdaws and Sparrows in ours with Red Kites overhead.

Small and medium winter birds to look out for in the park

The named birds in particular and sometimes near the adjoining gardens



Song Thrush



Starling

There may be more to add to the list? For example several years ago there were Tawny Owls and was it a Mistle Thrush we saw last year?

Birds

Large and medium-sized birds seen flying over or in the park



Canada Goose



Grey Heron



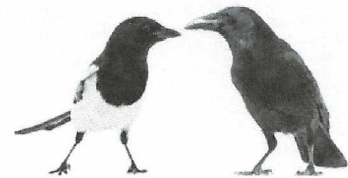
Red Kite



Buzzard



Herring Gull



Magpie

Crow



Wood Pigeon



Black-headed Gull summer/winter



Jackdaw



Collared Doves



Green Woodpecker



On sunny February days look out for Peacock butterflies! Any Fungi this month?

Risinghurst and Sandhills Parish Council February 2019

www.risinghurstsandhillsparishcouncil.com

Birds

My favourite small bird – a knitting needle with a ball of wool



Life-size Long-tailed Tit

You're most likely to spot Long-tailed tits flying in a line between trees because faced with an open space they gather together with urgent piercing "tsee tsee tsee" calls then one by one, following each other, they cross over calling excitedly.

At this time of year they form flocks of 6 to 17 birds, defending territories, roosting together for warmth and communicating with short rippling "tserr" calls mingled with clicking "tek" notes.

In March the flocks break up and the nest building begins. Male and female work together, sometimes taking up to 3 weeks, or if it's late in the season, a rush job of less than a week.



Birds



Their nest is egg-shaped with a side entrance near the top. built in a prickly bush or high up in the fork of a tree, from moss with lichen, interwoven cobwebs on the outside as camouflage. Inside, a feather lining, maybe as many as 1,500 feathers gathered along the way of from the bodies of dead birds who may well have been rivals!



If their nests fail after the beginning of May they may split up and become helpers at the nest of another usually related pair. Good survival instincts!

At the end of the breeding season, in June–July, the birds reform the winter flocks in their winter territory until next year's March. *Birds of a feather flock together?*

The poet John Clare loved them too, calling them “bumbarrels”, after their barrel-shaped nest?

And coy bumbarrels twenty in a drove

Flit down the hedgerow in the frozen plain

And hang on little twigs and start again.